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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Dems paint brighter fiscal picture

Gov. Pritzker slated to unveil what he has promised will be a balanced budget

By **Jeremy Gorner, Olivia Olander, Rick Pearson and Addison Wright** | Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Democratic leaders who had been bracing for a deficit of more than \$3 billion expressed confidence Tuesday that the outlook had improved, a day before Gov. JB Pritzker is set to unveil what he has promised will

be a balanced budget.

“I do think that there’s some pleasant surprises with revenue projections, but then there’s some other things that they’ve done to close the gap,” House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch of Hillside

said after a meeting in the governor’s Springfield office.

“Revenue projections are up,” he said, without elaborating.

No tax increases are expected in the governor’s proposed budget, which is set to include a small surplus, Welch said.

“It’s going to be a good — a better proposal than we were bracing for a couple months ago,” said Senate President Don Harmon, an Oak Park Democrat who was also at the budget briefing.

While projections inevitably change over time, the possibility of a surplus is surprising given that the governor’s budget office in November said it expected a deficit of about \$3.2 billion. With billions of dollars in federal pandemic money no longer available to Illinois, the next spending plan has promised to be a test of fiscal discipline for a Democratic governor who was forced to raise taxes by hundreds of millions of dollars last year to balance the budget.

Pritzker has said in recent weeks that tax hikes are a last resort as he prepared for this year’s proposal.

The state also faces uncertainty about federal funding under President Donald Trump.

Pritzker’s proposed operating budget is expected to total about \$55 billion, according to sources. The state’s current operating budget was set at \$53.1 billion, about a third higher than

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GOOD HAIR DAYS

How George E. Johnson made millions in the hair care industry while following the Golden Rule



By **Christopher Borrelli** | Chicago Tribune

George E. Johnson, at 97, is a rich man. He’s been a rich man since the 1960s. He’s owned yachts, cattle ranches and a home in France. Years ago, he took a French lover; they divorced after a short marriage. He lived in Glencoe much of his life. He had a tennis court and swimming pool, and when his first wife came home from Neiman Marcus carrying thousands of dollars’ worth of designer clothes, he blinked and showed concern, but Joan, his wife, said they had money, what was the worry? Johnson was a rich man.

His mother nicknamed him “The Rich Man” before he actually was a rich man. He acted like one. His mother left Mississippi at 18 and arrived in Chicago as part of the Great Migration. He grew up near Bronzeville and took small jobs as early as age 6. He waited tables, washed cars, swept floors, shined shoes. After he made a little cash, he took horseback riding lessons around Hyde Park. He bought wide-legged jodhpurs and liked to walk around wearing them. He would also carry a riding crop, just because.

“I worked my butt off and did things a young Black man didn’t do then,” he said recently. “I took my riding lessons in Washington Park. I went to the theater. I went to the opera. I dressed up for school every day. And I made money. I was never unemployed.”

The other morning he looked out across Chicago,

Above: George E. Johnson, 97, in his Chicago home Tuesday. Johnson founded Johnson Products Co., the maker of Afro Sheen and many other products. “By 1960, I was profit sharing,” he said. “My feeling was, look, these people helped make my money, why not share it?” **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

At left: Mayor Richard J. Daley, right, in 1969 with George E. Johnson, center, of Johnson Products, and businessman and banker Alvin Boutte. **CHICAGO TRIBUNE ARCHIVE**

At CPD, internal discipline increasing

Rise ties to ongoing slowdown in external corrective process

By **Sam Charles**
Chicago Tribune

While proceedings in high-profile police misconduct cases slowed to a trickle in 2024, the number of internal disciplinary actions initiated by Chicago Police Department supervisors nearly doubled from 2023, according to a Tribune analysis.

Records obtained via the Freedom of Information Act show CPD supervisors, mostly sergeants, filed more than 5,300 Summary Punishment Action Requests — “SPARs” — in 2024, a sharp increase from the 2,700 SPARs initiated in 2023.

The rise in internal CPD discipline comes as the external disciplinary process — where fewer, but more serious cases, such as those involving deadly force incidents, are handled — remains greatly curtailed as a legal fight carries on between the city and Fraternal Order of Police in the Illinois Appellate Court. No decision is expected anytime soon.

CPD’s overall staffing levels have remained effectively the same over the last two years, and the department has added only about two dozen new sergeants since the start of 2023, records show. But still, the uptick in SPARs — which, in theory, can help CPD leaders identify future misconduct patterns among rank-and-file officers — also coincides with long-standing concerns voiced by

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INSIDE

‘He’s someone we can learn a lot from’

The Cubs agreed to a deal to bring in infielder Justin Turner, 40. He will bring experience and mentorship to the clubhouse. **Chicago Sports**

A culinary curiosity in Western Springs

Petite Vie by chef Paul Virant brings buttery French market priced potatoes on a simple, yet inventive, menu. **Food & Health**

US, Russia pursue reset, partnership

Talks produce plan to solidify business, diplomatic relations

By **Anton Troianovski and Ismael Naar**
The New York Times

RIYADH, Saudi Arabia — The United States and Russia moved toward a startling reset of their relationship Tuesday, agreeing to work together on ending the Ukraine war, financial

investment and reestablishing normal relations. The meeting between senior officials from both countries was a striking display of friendliness after three years of U.S. efforts to isolate Moscow for its 2022 invasion.

After more than four hours of talks, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said both sides had agreed to work on a peace settlement for Ukraine as well as to explore “the incredible opportunities that exist to partner with the Russians,” both geopolitically and economically.

“We weren’t just listening to each other, but we heard each other,” said Sergey Lavrov, Russia’s foreign minister. “I have reason to believe that the American side started to better understand our positions.”

The meeting, the most extensive negotiations in more than three years between the two global powers, was the latest swerve by the Trump administration in abandoning Western efforts to punish

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Secretary of State Marco Rubio, right, greets Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov on Tuesday in Riyadh. **SAUDI PRESS AGENCY**

